

Cauliflower & Celery Root Soup SERVES 5 TO 6

This is one of the most surprising soups. It tastes rich and velvety and yet, with only two tablespoons of cream in it, it's a healthy vegetable soup. Celery root and fennel give it a wonderful depth of flavor and the homemade croutons and drizzle of olive oil at the end are delicious additions.



Fennel adds a very subtle layer of flavor to the cauliflower and celery root.

- ¼ cup good olive oil, plus extra for serving
- 2 cups chopped yellow onions (2 onions)
- 2 cups (1-inch-diced) celery root
- 2 cups (1-inch-diced) fennel, core and stalks removed
- 2 pounds cauliflower, cored and cut into florets (1 medium)
- 2 cups good chicken stock, preferably homemade (page 62)
- Kosher salt
- 2 tablespoons heavy cream
- Homemade Croutons, for serving (recipe follows)
- Chopped fresh chives, for serving

Heat the olive oil in a heavy-bottomed pot or Dutch oven, such as Le Creuset. Add the onions and sauté over medium-low heat for 8 to 10 minutes, stirring occasionally, until tender but not browned. Stir in the celery root and fennel and sauté for 5 minutes, stirring occasionally. Add the cauliflower, chicken stock, and 2 teaspoons of salt. Bring to a boil, lower the heat, cover, and simmer for 25 to 30 minutes, until the vegetables are very tender. Add 3 cups of water, bring to a boil, lower the heat, and simmer uncovered for 20 minutes.

Working in batches, purée the soup in a blender, until very smooth. (Don't fill the blender more than half full or it will overflow!) Pour the blended soup into a large saucepan, stir in the cream, and add 1 or 2 teaspoons of salt, depending on the saltiness of the chicken stock. Reheat the soup over medium-low heat. Ladle into soup bowls, sprinkle with croutons and chives, and drizzle with olive oil. Serve hot.

MAKE IT AHEAD: Prepare the soup and refrigerate for up to 1 week or freeze for up to 3 months. Reheat before serving. Make the croutons up to 5 days ahead.



Homemade Croutons MAKES ABOUT 2 CUPS

I stash leftover bread in the freezer and use it to make these croutons.

2 tablespoons good olive oil

2 cups (½-inch-diced) bread from a country loaf, crusts removed

Kosher salt

Heat the olive oil in a large (10-inch) sauté pan until hot. Add the bread and cook over medium heat, tossing frequently, until the bread is evenly toasted and browned. Sprinkle with salt.

